Winter Run

By Brian O'Neill

INTRODUCTION

Fishing trips with my dad would begin with a lesson on knot tying, or when to set the hook, but if I waited long enough dad would begin to tell stories. Each fishing story told of relationships with brothers, or uncles, or friends. If you unfolded the story you could see love between family members -- they revealed something new about the man I cherished the most.

My dad is no longer with us – a victim of a massive heart attack. But he is still here (put hand on heart) in the stories I will pass on to my kids. I suspect my children will be touched in the same way I was as a child...by the stories.

Brian O'Neill in his poem Winter Run brings the family tradition of steelhead fishing in Indiana to life with memories and stories of his own. You can almost feel the water, smell the outdoors and envy the memories he has of his father. Winter Run by Brian O'Neill

In Northern Indiana

loam returns to sand.

Gulls scream over breakers.

The French knelt believing

it was the end of America.

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Imagine La Salle's surprise,

or Pierre Navarre flat

on his back: fresh water

roaring in like the sea;

cactus, wild roses, and pine

rooted in the same dune, sturgeon

running rivers, and jumbo perch.

On a bridge south of Gary

millfire blots out the stars

I've tasted its metallic sourdough.

Winter makes it clean somehow:

a good wind off the lake, snow

thick as goose down, and he stacks

were never there, only the silence

a blizzard makes, rivers sliding

under glass, the open pools steaming

Another kind of waking dream,

steelhead run where snaggers

take the channel. Planted from

Pacific stock, they surge and flash

in unfamiliar water because the sadness

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of rivers is real: it ruined the sleep
of Michigan lumber barons
who logged whole water sheds
and sunk holes for ore, their tailings
left to leach a thousand years,
who felt the river rise in sleep
and a final exhalation disappear
in a dark that gave no reply;
towns as bankrupt as the runs
they were named for:
Iron River and Grayling
and the milltown where scarfers swear
a cougar cleared the fence
at Inland Steel: a hundred
desperate sightings followed,
in dune grass and scrub, between stacked
oil drums and silos filled with methane,
all along the lake shore ringed in fie.
I saw the foreman grin and the three
fingers on his right hand dance.
"These sons of bitching fingers,"

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he told us, "the three who made it
up the river can't stand the quiet water.
Sometimes I swear the other two
were never lost. I'll look down
and for a second the hand is whole.
It even feels whole, then it's gone.
It's come to that with cougars.
It's why the steelhead run the Calumet,"
Johansen said, "it's why
the man's a foreman" and David said,
"the old man's full of shit."
Underneatht the stab and parry,
steelhead make a winter run,
wherever we imagine a line can be thrown,
up the discharge of NIPSCO generators,
up dredged rivers steaming like soup:
Trail Creek the best of the lot,
tea colored as if stained by cedar,
clear enough to see a gravel bottom die
in the backwater behind the jams.
It's where we drove one New Year's Eve

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to try out luck – again to test the ice
and wade a waist-deep current.
You gave me the good hole to work,
as my father might have done,
or a brother, then struggled upstream
through the drifts. Eight months
since my father died. Not a soul left
on this earth to mourn my lack of sense
or tell me to be in before dark.
Now semis are gearing down
on the iced bridge and the dark
setting in, I open his tackle box
and tie on the Little Cleo
I gave him one Christmas for a joke.
Stainless steel pressed into a spoon.
On the convex side: a funny lime body
under eight or nine yellow eyes,
some bigger than others. On the concave:
Little Cleo herself, bare-breasted,
hands locked behind her head,
a treble hook beneath. A form of life

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meant to imitate another form of life.
I cast her out as a last recourse.
The dead-drift to deep water. The surprise
of a good strike. *Like the day my father*
swam me to the drop off, where weeds
die out for lack of light,
and pike hand in the predatory silence.
There was that great empty space
beneath us. Reasoning failed
to assure me of a bottom.
It was not so much sinking, then,
but fear of what might rise
that enlarged my arms and stiffened
the flutter in my legs.
I did not turn back but imagined
the necessity of continuing
because there was nowhere else to go.
I had left the earth. I had made
the water hum with hard
and certain strokes. Then my father
called me back. Now I pull

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the fear upward, and the steelhead
rises to a surface more alien
than the sad river he was brought to,
sleek as a zeppelin, the color of sky,
the beautiful, barbed, pale tongue
exposed along a pearl jaw. You slide
the bank like an otter, enter
without a splash, the long-handled net
held exactly where it must b,
repeating what we know.
Ease him out with roots whole
and unbroken. Lay him in the snow
the gills already stunned,
the eye fixed. We should smoke
the flesh in hickory, invent
a wilderness to surround our fear,
but the world burns all along
the floodlit highway –
the lamp posts hum and shudder.
Wind has driven clouds
right to the ground Roads

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are drifting over. The window
that fogged with my father's breath
is clear. His old friend in Grayling
wears his grief without despair
or bitterness. Even so, he talks
some nights as if talking all morning
weren't enough, clips a surgeon's knot
and quits because his hands
are stiff, and the fly belongs
to dreams of kelp and tidal flats
where steelhead taste freshwater
in the wide estuaries. He wants
the grayling back for rivers
that never reach the sea.
His wife smiles at peacock hurl
and deer hair, the Black
Demon Streamer clamped in its vise,
the half-turned hackle,
the steelhead streaming in the snow
at Gary, the extinct replaced
by the dispossessed. For Mishawaka,

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Elkhart, Wakarusa, Potawatomi
For Osceola, Oswego, Maxinkuckee.
For my grandfather laying track
from Chicago to South Bend.
For Italians and Germans and Irish
buried under rails. For Blacks marooned
in snow as north as they could walk,
who found no work or love but their own,
who held one another and did not freeze
in the shacks outside Cassopolis,
Vandalia, White Pigeon, where they dug in
and lived by what they scratched
from the dirt, and the mothers
who never threw one scrap away,
husked dried beans, canned
over coal fires. For my mother
and the women who put off pleasure
attending the needs, always the needs
of others. For my father couting
automotive parts let go without notice
and the men he worked with who carried

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the week without question, the ones
who broke under fluorescent tedium.
For families driving north for perch,
who lay their sleeping children down,
drank whisky in the musty cabins and talk.
There are nights when I give myself
completely up to the emptiness of sleep,
when language slides unto its sheath
and nothing remains but the spine
attending the tidal pull of the heart,
and the spirit gathers itself
in a stillness out of which
the past is perpetually created
like a pulse, because the past is nothing
until it is imagined, and because
whatever we are begins there
and is real: a wide, slow river,
in which everything we have forgotten
or felt without knowing – a word
whispered in our ear before we knew
what the word was – rises,

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and a ripple breaks the flat surface
the way grayling break a pool so gently
you'd think it was a stonefly hatching
the rings concentrically gliding outward,
one within the other. The dream
you never remember arrives like that,
and sometimes it's a gift, a cleansing,
though we hardly know it, leaving only
the barest trace of a feeling
we cannot name, so that I shake myself
and find nothing buy my two hands
and a stiff right knee. An August moon
cutting the night haze. The light
around my wife's red hair.
My two sons lost in sleep.
All I can offer is the image
they've made of me, the one
they'll lean into like a hard current –
below them, steelhead moving in
for another winter run.

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